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PoliSci 393M
Final Paper – Media Coverage of War in Ukraine

Introduction

The capability to use one's voice is intertwined with the functionality of democracy, given the fact that the First Amendment of the U.S. Constitution protects freedom of religion, speech, press, to peacefully assemble, and petition the government for a redress of grievances. Media provides a platform for the voices of the people through its four functions – watchdog, election forum, informing society, and representing society. However, through political and market pressures, this voice may be influenced to cover other objectives and interests, reflecting the aforementioned factors rather than the general public. This relationship between media and society can influence both domestic and international affairs, which in turn can shape the policymaking processes for both levels of governance. The media coverage of the ongoing Russo-Ukrainian War acts as a case study through which it can be better understood how this interrelation shapes who has a voice in coverage of foreign wars.

Background

This latest invasion of Ukraine by the Russian government has been the second in the past decade, with Crimea having been annexed in 2014. Relations between Ukraine and Russia are extremely nuanced. Up until 1991, it had been the second most influential and important republic of the Soviet Union, only behind Russia, due to the significance of its agriculture and defense industries (Masters, 2023). In the proceeding almost 33 years since, Ukraine has undergone the process of attempting to navigate increasing relations with Western countries and its cultural, historical, and political ties with Russia. This balancing act came to a culmination in 2014 with the former Ukrainian President Viktor Yanukovich dismissing a deal that would have improved economic integration with the European Union. This decision resulted in protests, which were met with attempts to violently repress protestors, as Yanukovich deployed security forces. However, these attempts were not successful, and Yanukovich subsequently fled to Russia. Only a month later, the Russian government invaded Crimea resulting in a war and the first invasion of a European country by another European country since World War II, with Russian President Vladimir Putin claiming that Russian-speaking Ukrainians needed to be protected from a supposedly fascist Ukrainian government. This conflict in Crimea heightened tensions in other regions, such as Donetsk and Luhansk. In response to the Russian military buildup and the unsuccessful Minsk Accords, NATO and the United States also deployed troops in surrounding NATO countries in an attempt to deter. Tensions continued to rise and reached a climax on February 24th, 2024 when Putin announced a “full-scale land, sea, and air invasion of Ukraine”, employing the same justification as he had in 2014 (Center for Preventative Action, 2024).

Reacting to this declaration of war, America, the EU, other Western allies, and intergovernmental organizations, such as the United Nations (UN) and the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), announced sanctions against major Russian government officials, banks, and businesses, and denounced the invasion (Center for Preventative Action, 2024). The “restoration of Ukraine's territorial integrity and sovereignty” has been a shared objective (Masters, 2023). Overall, as of April 24th, 2024, Ukraine has acquired around \$278 billion, with

\$75 billion having been given by the United States of America (Center for Preventative Action, 2024). While this foreign aid has provided substantial benefits and advantages to the Ukrainian efforts, Russia remains in control of 18% of Ukraine after two years of fighting which has involved the death of 30,000 civilians and internal displacement of 3.7 million people. Furthermore, 6.5 million people have left Ukraine, with 14.6 million needing humanitarian aid (Center for Preventative Action, 2024). These statistics highlight the persistent nature of this conflict, thereby suggesting the need for continued and sustained aid to Ukraine against Russian aggression. With around 27% of aid coming from the United States, as well as a continued need for aid, American foreign policy making in regard to NATO and Ukraine has been a major source of discussion domestically. In turn, American media coverage has focused substantially on the domestic and international implications of the war in relation to America's standing.

Research Questions

Due to this significance of the conflict, we sought to observe the American media coverage of the Russo-Ukrainian War and compare the coverage from the initial invasion in February of 2022 to the current coverage in 2024. The main focus of this research project was to answer the question: *How has the media coverage regarding the War in Ukraine changed since Russia's invasion in 2022 to now in 2024?* To examine this overarching question in greater detail to better gauge any evolution in article content, rhetoric, and voice, we asked niche questions. For example, *What kinds of actors are being utilized as sources, What actors are stories being focused on or written about? Is the coverage focusing on politics, events, or people? Is the content focusing on violence, refugees, or foreign aid?, and Has the language become more graphic or violent?*

Data & Methods

The process of compiling a corpus of articles to analyze involved various steps. We employed the Nexus Uni database, and used the search terms "Ukraine", "Russia" and "invasion", which produced a multitude of articles. To further narrow the results and make comparisons between the beginning of the invasion to the present, we constructed two sets of time periods. Period 1 contained articles from February 24th, 2022 until March 1st, 2022. Period 2 was composed of articles between the dates of February 24th, 2024 and March 11th, 2024. Furthermore, we chose The New York Times, Atlanta Journal-Constitution, and the Chicago Daily Herald in order to obtain a broad collection of publications from different regions of the United States. This data collection process resulted in a corpus of 91 articles total, with 49.45% being from The New York Times, 26.37% from Chicago Daily Herald, and 22% from the Atlanta Journal-Constitution. 54.95% of the articles were published in Period 1 and 45.05% were published in Period 2. Overall in terms of political ideology, the majority (74.73%) of articles were categorized as slightly left by Allsides Rating, with the remaining articles (25.27%) being considered center.

With a corpus of articles, the next step in the process was creating and implementing a coding scheme¹. This coding scheme produced univariate and bivariate statistical analyses. The first section was article information. To obtain basic knowledge about the articles we coded for the Allsides Rating and the Period for which the articles were published in. The next section was content, which we coded for the primary and secondary topics of each article. This list of topics is as follows: Aid/Resources, Military Actions, the Death Toll, International Organizations,

¹ See Appendix

Leaders, Refugees, Sanctions/Economic Disruptions, Political Impact, Social Impact and Other. Then we observed the articles' rhetoric from four different perspectives – violence, economic impact, political impact, and social impact. We coded for whether it was mentioned or not in the article, what kind of impact was discussed, who was being impacted, and whether it was being described statistically or emotively. Lastly, we examined the voice of the articles by coding for the focus of the article, who was mentioned as a source, and who was specifically quoted as a source.

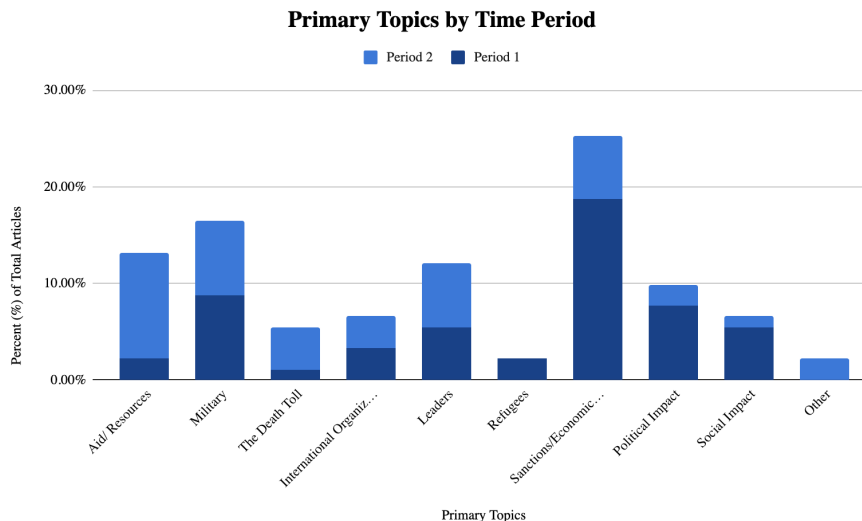
Results

The results of this coding scheme provided insight and information into how media coverage of a foreign war may change throughout the conflict.

Content

Overall in regards to the content of the articles, sanctions and other economic disruptions were the primary topics of articles, with 25% of articles primarily addressing this aspect of the war, with other notable percentages being military comprising 16.5%, aid and resources making up 13.2% and leaders making up 12.1%. However, separating the data by Period highlights a shift in content over time, as can be seen in Figure 1. Aid and resources and the death toll were the primary topics in Period 1. However, the economic, political, and social implications of the war were the primary topics in Period 2. It should be noted that international organizations and leaders were covered consistently throughout both periods.

Figure 1



Rhetoric

Examining the rhetoric of the articles revealed that overall, a large majority of articles (73.63%) included political impact. A little less than half (44%) of the articles emphasized the economic impact, with almost a third (31%) highlighting the social impact and slightly more than a quarter of articles stressed the violence of the war. It can be observed that articles printed in Period 1 focused on the political impact and economic impact a similar amount, with 62% of articles highlighting the political impact and 54% emphasizing the economic impact. Violence

(30%) and the social impact (38%) were featured much less. However, 87.80% of articles in Period 2 accentuated the political impact, with articles underscoring the economic impact (31.71%), social impact (21.95%), and violence (21.95%) much less. Despite the small percentage that underlined the violence of the conflict, the consistency of Ukrainian citizens and soldiers being described as the victims and Putin and the Russian government being labeled as the perpetrators of violence showcases Ukrainians defending themselves from Russian aggression. Regarding the media coverage surrounding the economic impacts, both periods featured the sanctions and financial markets, however, Period 1 made more mentions of industry disruptions and Period 2 focused more on the macroeconomic impacts. There is a considerable change between 2022 and now in terms of what kind of political impact is being discussed in the media. Articles in Period 1 tended to focus primarily on the international isolation of Russia, while articles published in Period 2 discussed alliances and international security measures. This shift highlights the increase in debates surrounding the means and degree to which Ukraine's allies can support Ukraine's efforts, with the uptick of mentions of international isolation of Russia in Period 2 potentially being due to the reactions of countries against Russia's attack on Ukraine. Moreover, media coverage in Period 1 mostly discussed the domestic politics of Russia and America, while coverage in Period 2 was focused primarily on the politics of international relations and intergovernmental organizations. This alteration can be attributed to the media initially providing context to the readers in regards to Russia's claimed justification for invading Ukraine, and how the war will impact American society. The shift in focus toward the politics of the international community suggests that the war is being perceived from a more global perspective, as many states have a stake in the matter. There was also a noticeable shift in the coverage of the social impact of the war, with articles printed in Period 1 writing most about the displacement of people and articles in Period 2 bringing awareness to the human rights violations that have occurred. Across all four perspectives, statistical language was used more often than emotive language. However, it is important to note that when it was employed, emotive language was used most often to describe the social impacts and violence.

Voice

There was a general shift between the initial invasion and two years later in who was the focus and who had a voice in the coverage of the Russo-Ukrainian War. Although the focus of the media coverage revealed that overall, the Biden administration and Putin were the main focus, the focuses of Period 1 and Period 2 differed. Articles from Period 1 focused more on the United Nations, the private sector, and Ukrainian citizens, while those from Period 2 concentrated largely on NATO, European leaders, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, and the agencies of the U.S. Executive branch. Figures 2 and 3 convey who is being used as a source, be it mentioned or directly quoted. Overall, Putin, Zelenskyy, other European leaders, and the Biden administration were mentioned as sources and U.S. Congress and Russian government officials were constantly quoted in articles in both periods. Coverage in Period 1 most likely mentioned and frequently quoted Putin, the private sector, Ukrainian citizens, the UN, and other NGOs and IGOs as sources of information. Coverage in Period 2 mentioned the U.S. Congress and NATO as sources and often quoted NATO, Russian citizens, the Biden administration, Zelenskyy, and the U.S. Executive branch agencies. Although 'Other' makes up a large portion of the responses, this category is mostly composed of quotations and mentions of former President Donald Trump. Furthermore, the high rates of quotations and mentions of U.S.

Congressional members and Trump indicate how the coverage of international affairs, in this specific case a foreign war, is connected to domestic pressures. It can also be observed that refugees were never quoted or mentioned as sources of information.

Figure 2

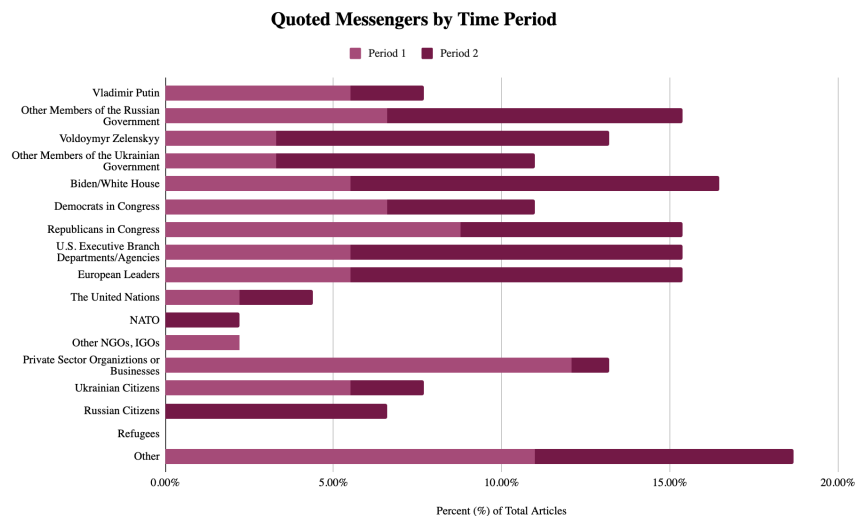
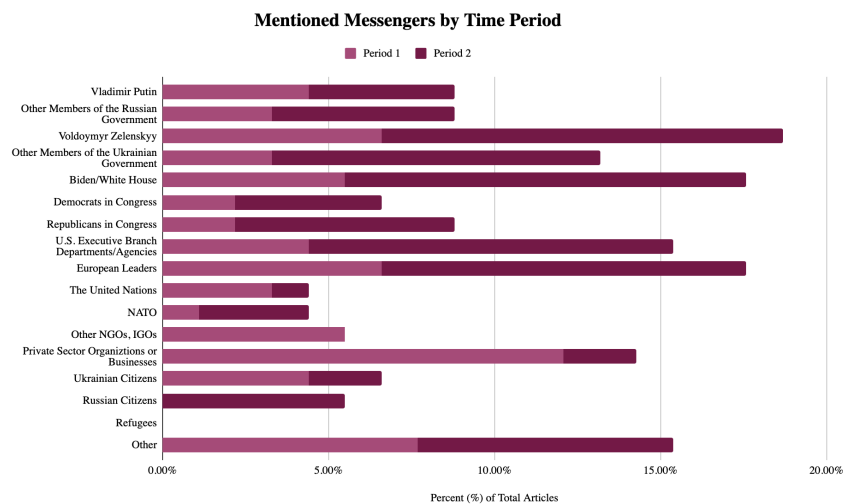


Figure 3



Takeaways

Although there has been some evolution in coverage over the past two years since Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022, there remains a consistent focus on international affairs, alliances, and the domestic implications concerning the United States. Although Ukrainian citizens, the private sector, and NGOs were utilized as sources, coverage of the Russo-Ukrainian war relies heavily on government officials of various countries, suggesting that the voice of the articles reflects the

interests, beliefs, and objectives of government leaders. The lack of coverage of the violence and social impact and voice given to refugees in preference to the economic and political impacts and government official statements highlights how Lance Bennett's theory of indexing accurately describes how international affairs, specifically in this case a foreign war, is covered. Bennett argues that "mass media news professionals... tend to index the range of voices and viewpoints in both news and editorials according to the range of views expressed in mainstream government's debate about a given topic" (Bennett, 1990). Despite the humanitarian crisis that is occurring due to the conflict, the majority of the articles are focused on the politics and economics of the situation, and what it may mean for American politics, NATO, and the stability and functionality of these alliances in light of severe and intense Russian aggression. Moreover, this can also be noted in U.S. Congressional officials and Trump being quoted frequently in connection to a bill – which has since then become an act – that would provide Ukraine with foreign aid, which was being utilized in domestic politics.

With a foreign war being fought on another continent, American society requires and relies on the media to inform them of the ongoing in Ukraine. The media has done a satisfactory job of providing information to inform the American public about the war in Ukraine in terms of its implications and the stakes. However, as our research project revealed, the majority of the sources which were utilized by the publications were American, Ukrainian, Russian, and other European government leaders and officials, meaning that the statements of politicians and bureaucrats guide the coverage of the war. This is also reminiscent of Bennett's indexing theory as he suggests that "journalists are more likely to index legitimate voices in the news according to the range of views expressed by prominent officials and members of institutional power blocs likely to influence the outcome of a situation" (Bennett, 1990). Indexing in war coverage occurs often, as it can be noted in the Vietnam War and Iraq War albeit the government was severely limiting reporters' access. The ability for the media to cover a foreign war without being too greatly indexed by the government depends on the government's interests and objectives in regard to the war and to the domestic politics and by association pressures of the moment. Therefore, what the readers of The New York Times, Atlanta Journal-Constitution, and the Chicago Daily Herald are consuming and are being informed about has been indexed by, as Bennett puts it, the "mainstream government's debate". Although this may be the case currently, the American media must increase its coverage of the humanitarian crisis and the social ramifications of the war in Ukraine. Coverage of the experiences of Ukrainian citizens would allow the American public to emotionally understand the reality of living through a war. If coverage of the Russo-Ukrainian war would combine raising awareness of the humanitarian crisis with explaining the social, economic and political implications, both domestically and internationally, American society would be better informed thereby improving the media's function of informing the public.

References

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Appendix

POLISCI 393M Ukraine & Russia Conflict: Coding Scheme

Dimension	Narrative Component	Description	Codes
Article Information		AllSides Rating <u>NOTE:</u> New York Times (News): 2 New York Times (Opinion): 1 The Daily Herald (Chicago): 3 Atlanta Journal-Constitution: 2 The Associated Press: 2	1: Left 2: Lean Left 3: Center 4: Lean Right 5: Right
		Time Period	1: Immediately after invasion 2: Two Years Post Invasion

Dimension	Narrative Component	Description	Codes
Content (A)	Topic (1)	What topic is this item primarily about? (a)	1: Aid/Resources 2: Military Actions 3: The Death Toll 4: International Organizations 5: Leaders 6: Refugees 7: Sanctions/ Economic Disruptions 8: Political Impact 9: Social Impact 10: Other
		What other topic is this item about (b)	1: Aid/Resources 2: Military Actions 3: The Death Toll 4: International Organizations 5: Leaders 6: Refugees 7: Sanctions/ Economic Disruptions 8: Political Impact 9: Social Impact 10: Other

Dimension	Narrative Component	Description	Codes
Rhetoric (B)	Violence (1)	Are violent events and circumstances mentioned in the item? (a) If code 0 appears in (a), STOP coding this item and continue with the next item (2).	0: No 1: Yes
		Who is described as the victim? (b) Pick up to 2	0: None 1: Women 2: Children 3: Ukrainian Citizens 4: Ukrainian Soldiers 5: Russian soldiers 6: Russian Citizens 7: Other
		Who is described as the perpetrator? (c) Pick up to 2	0: None 1: Russian Government 2: Mercenaries 3: Vladimir Putin 4: Russian Soldiers 5: Other
		What kind of language is used? (d)	1: Statistical/Events 2: Emotive/Graphic
	Economic Impact (2)	Does the item mention any economic impact? (a) If code 0 appears in (a), STOP coding this item and continue with the next item (3).	0: No 1: Yes
		What kind of economic impact is mentioned? (b)	0: None 1: Sanctions 2: Industry Disruptions 3: Macroeconomic 4: Financial Markets 5: Other
		Who is feeling the economic impact? (c)	0: None 1: Russia 2: Ukraine 3: United States 4: Global 5: Other

		What kind of language is used? (d)	1: Statistical/Events 2: Emotive/Graphic
	Political Impact (3)	Does the item mention any political impact? (a) If code 0 appears in (a), STOP coding this item and continue with the next item (4).	0: No 1: Yes
		What level/kind of politics is focused on? (b)	0: None 1: American domestic politics 2: EU politics 3: Ukrainian politics 4: IGOs (UN, NATO) politics 5: International relations 6: Russian politics 7: Other
		What kind of political impact is mentioned? (c)	0: None 1: Alliances 2: International Security measures 3: International Law 4: International Isolation of Russia 5: Refugee/Asylum Policy 6: Other
		What kind of language is used? (d)	1: Statistical/Events 2: Emotive/Graphic
	Social Impact (4)	Does the item mention any social impact? (a) If code 0 appears in (a), STOP coding this item and continue with the next item (C).	0: No 1: Yes
		What kind of social impact is mentioned? (b)	0: None 1: Displacement of people 2: Human Rights Violations 3: Protests 4: Other
		What kind of language is used? (c)	1: Statistical/Events 2: Emotive/Graphic

Dimension	Narrative Component	Description	Codes
Voice (C)	Focus of the Item (1)	Who is the main focus of this item (a) (List up to 3 in order)	0: No sources mentioned or quoted by name 1: Vladimir Putin 2: Other members of the Russian government 3: Volodymyr Zelenskyy 4: Other members of the Ukrainian government 5: Biden/White House 6: Democrats in Congress 7: Republicans in Congress 8: U.S. Executive Branch Departments/Agencies 9: European leaders 10: The United Nations 11: NATO 12: Other NGOs, IGOs 13: Private organizations / their members 14: Ukrainian citizens 15: Russian citizens 16: Refugees 17: Academia /Experts 18: Other
	Mentioned Messengers (2)	Who is mentioned as a source by name? (a) List up to three in order.	0: No sources mentioned or quoted by name 1: Vladimir Putin 2: Other members of the Russian government 3: Volodymyr Zelenskyy 4: Other members of the Ukrainian government 5: Biden/White House 6: Democrats in Congress 7: Republicans in Congress 8: U.S. Executive Branch Departments/Agencies 9: European leaders 10: The United Nations 11: NATO 12: Other NGOs, IGOs 13: Private organizations / their members 14: Ukrainian citizens 15: Russian citizens 16: Refugees 17: Academia / Experts 18: Other

	Quoted Messengers (3)	Who is quoted as a source by name? (a) List up to three in order.	0: No sources mentioned or quoted by name 1: Vladimir Putin 2: Other members of the Russian government 3: Volodymyr Zelenskyy 4: Other members of the Ukrainian government 5: Biden/White House 6: Democrats in Congress 7: Republicans in Congress 8: U.S. Executive Branch Departments/Agencies 9: European leaders 10: The United Nations 11: NATO 12: Other NGOs, IGOs 13: Private organizations/ their members 14: Ukrainian citizens 15: Russian citizens 16: Refugees 17: Academia 18: Other
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